

Q When will my baby have to be immunized?

Your baby should have received his first immunization in the hospital. His immunization program will continue through his first year and beyond, with additional vaccinations at his doctor appointments at 1, 2, 4, 6, and 12 months.

IMMUNIZATION PROGRAM

In addition to newborn shots, further vaccinations are given in early childhood and in the adolescent years. A detailed breakdown of the immunization program is given in this table.

AGE	VACCINE RECEIVED	REASON
Birth	HepB	Protects against hepatitis B
1–2 months	HepB	Second dose
2 months	DtaP	Protects against diphtheria, tetanus, and pertussis (whooping cough)
	RV	Protects against rotavirus
	Hib	Protects against Haemophilus influenzae type b
	PCV13	Protects against Pneumococcal conjugate
4 months	IPV	Protects against poliovirus
	DTaP	Second dose
	RV	Second dose
	Hib	Second dose
	PCV13	Second dose
	IPV	Protects against poliovirus
6 months	DTaP	Third dose
	RV (in some cases)	Third dose (depends on the vaccine used)
	Hib (in some cases)	Third dose (depends on the vaccine used)
	PCV13	Third dose
6–18 months	HepB	Third dose
	IPV	Third dose
6–24 months	IIV	Inactivated influenza vaccine should be given annually to protect against influenza (flu); one or two doses may be required the first year. After age two, the annual vaccine can either be IIV or LAIV (live attenuated influenza vaccine).
12–15 months	Hib	Third or fourth dose
	PCV13	Fourth dose
	MMR	Protects against measles, mumps, and rubella (German measles)
	VAR	Protects against varicella (chicken pox)
15–18 months	DTaP	Fourth dose

Q What exactly do immunizations do and why are they needed?

Being immunized protects your baby from developing potentially serious illnesses.

Immunity is a natural, learned process in the body; once we are exposed to an infection, our body creates antibodies to resist it in the future. A vaccine is a very diluted version of a disease, usually given by injection, designed to let your baby develop immunity to the disease without actually catching it.

All new babies have some immunity from their mother, but this effect wears off after about two months, which is why immunizations begin after this age.

Q My friend said my baby doesn't have to have immunizations. Is it true that I can refuse them?

Your consent will be asked before any of the routine vaccines offered for your baby (see chart, left) are given. If you decide against allowing your baby to have a vaccination, your pediatrician should report this in your baby's records.

Do, however, carefully weigh the benefits against potential risks before deciding not to immunize your child. Vaccination programs have successfully managed to significantly reduce or eliminate many serious and fatal diseases. If you don't vaccinate your child, you are not just increasing your child's risk of contracting a disease, but you are also affecting what's termed "herd immunity"—an effect of vaccination that makes it difficult for a disease to pass around the general populace when enough people have been immunized.

Side effects

The side effects of vaccinations tend to be mild (see opposite)—more serious side effects are rare. Some parents worry that having several vaccinations at one time could weaken their young baby's immune system. However, just a tiny fraction of the immune system is involved in creating the antibodies against live vaccines. In reality, your baby is exposed to many bacteria and viruses that are far stronger than the weakened bacteria and viruses given in vaccines, and his body handles these perfectly well.